

Alberta Recovery Model: Compassionate Intervention

A path to recovery

Addiction is an illness that if left untreated can worsen and can eventually cause a person to lose their ability to make good decisions regarding their health and wellbeing.

Compassionate intervention will allow adult family members, guardians, healthcare professionals, peace or police officers to request a treatment order for those whose addiction or substance use has made them a danger to themselves or others. Eligible individuals will receive assessment, stabilization, treatment and aftercare support.

The proposed compassionate intervention legislation is a made-in-Alberta strategy that will offer a path to treatment and recovery for individuals who cannot help themselves.

Eligibility

Adults would have to be likely to cause substantial harm to themselves or others within a reasonable time due to their substance use or addiction.

For youth, the threshold would be slightly lower, to allow an intervention before the point of imminent danger and life-threatening harm.

How it will work



Application submitted

An adult family member, guardian, healthcare professional, police or peace officer completes an application for an individual to be considered for compassionate intervention treatment.



Application reviewed

A statutory director and delegated team review applications for completeness.

Completed applications are forwarded to the compassionate intervention commission, an independent body responsible for making legally binding decisions. Incomplete applications are rejected, with alternate care options provided.



Assessment determination

An independent commission member (lawyer) reviews the application and determines if an individual meets the criteria for an up to 72-hour assessment period.

If criteria are met, the lawyer commission member issues an apprehension order and an assessment order. If not, the application is dismissed and the applicant will be provided with information on alternate care options.



Apprehension and conveyance

Police locate and transport the patient to a compassionate intervention centre for assessment.

Police can transfer patient care to peace officers for conveyance.



Assessment and detox

Patients are under the care of a treatment team. They receive medical withdrawal support and/or initial stabilization, as well as screening, physical examinations and other assessments to determine the risk factors associated with their substance use and addiction and their overall health and wellness.

[Alberta.ca/compassionate-intervention](https://alberta.ca/compassionate-intervention)

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Classification: Public





Information gathered

The statutory director and delegated team compile supporting documentation.

This includes the treatment team's assessment findings, as well as any additional information such as police records, health records and impact statements.



Commission hearing

A three-person commission panel (lawyer, physician and member of the public) reviews the information to determine if the patient is eligible for a care plan.

Participants: commission members, the patient, the statutory director, the medical director, legal counsel/advocate (if requested), the guardian (if applicable) and family members (impact statements).

If criteria are met, a care plan is issued. If not, the patient is discharged with support referrals.



Treatment

Two types of care plans:

- Secure care plan: up to three months of treatment in a compassionate intervention centre.
- Community-based care plan: up to six months of treatment in a community-based setting.

Care plans can be renewed or amended if the patient continues to meet criteria.



Aftercare

Every patient leaves the compassionate intervention system with a discharge plan for ongoing supports and services.

This may include continuing treatment in a recovery community or another community bed-based program, day programming, psychiatric care and/or ongoing work with a recovery coach. It may also include help to find housing, employment, skills training and more.

Key roles

Commission	Families and guardians	Police and peace officers	Recovery Alberta
– Independent, quasi-judicial body appointed by the Lieutenant Governor in Council. • Responsible for making legally binding treatment decisions. • Lawyers, physicians and members of the public.	• Submit applications. • Provide impact statements/attend commission hearings (as applicable). • Provide treatment consent for youth (as applicable). • Support patients in their recovery journey.	• Submit applications. • Apprehend individuals (police). • Convey individuals to compassionate intervention centres.	• Provincial health agency. • Operates compassionate intervention centres, under the medical director's leadership. • Conducts assessments, provides stabilization and treatment, offers ongoing supports and services.
Statutory director and delegated team	Community-based organizations	Legal counsel and Mental Health Patient Advocate	Canadian Centre of Recovery Excellence
• Government of Alberta employees embedded within Mental Health and Addiction. • Supports the commission to make evidence-informed decisions (manages applications, collects information, acts as a key coordinator).	• Provide treatment to individuals issued a community care plan (designated service providers). • Provide ongoing supports and services to support long-term recovery after discharge.	• Offers advice, guidance and advocacy. • Legal counsel representation at hearings. • Available at an individual's request.	• Leads evaluation efforts to inform evidence-based decisions. • Monitors outcomes of compassionate intervention.

Rights, reviews and appeals

Individuals will be informed of their rights, have access to legal counsel and the Alberta Mental Health Patient Advocate and be able to appeal decisions.

Treatment decisions will be reviewed at regular six-week intervals and upon request to ensure treatment is effective and being provided in the least restrictive and least intrusive manner.

Care plan decisions can be appealed. A three-person commission appeal panel must convene within seven days of an appeal being filed. Patients may request legal support during this process. Appeal decisions will be final, subject to judicial review through the Court of King's Bench.

The collection, use and disclosure of personal and health information will comply with privacy laws such as the *Health Information Act*, *Personal Information Protection Act* and the *Freedom of Information and Protection of Privacy Act*.

Right to refuse treatment

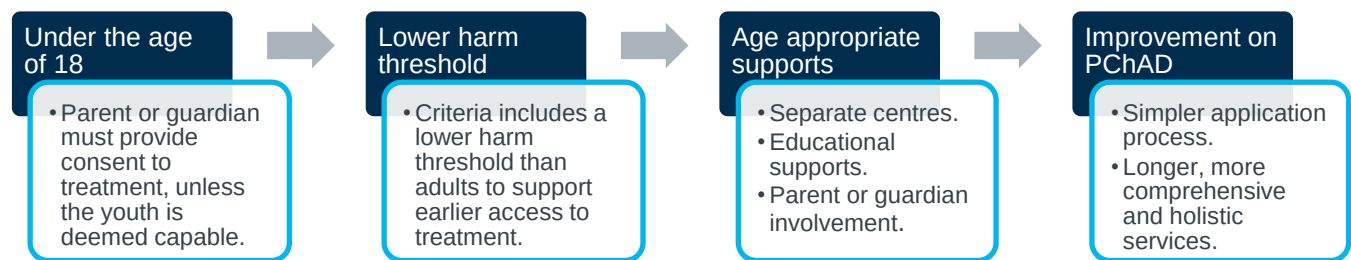
Patients will be asked if they consent to treatment.

The legislation specifies certain treatment a patient cannot refuse. A patient cannot refuse to:

- Be observed, monitored and assessed by the treatment team.
- Receive clinical advice.
- Take medications to treat their substance use or addiction that are authorized by the commission and prescribed and administered by the health professional who is treating them.

This is similar to the *Mental Health Act*.

Youth



The *Protection of Children Abusing Drugs Act* (PChAD) will be repealed when compassionate intervention is implemented. With long-term treatment, an easier application process and increased family involvement, compassionate intervention will be a significant improvement to PChAD.

Cultural connections

Building and maintaining ties to culture and community are essential elements of recovery for many First Nations and Métis peoples. Compassionate intervention will include the ability for First Nations and Métis to enter into an agreement with the Minister and integrate their unique practices and traditions into the compassionate intervention process.

Compassionate intervention centres

An investment of \$180 million is supporting the construction of the Northern and Southern Alberta Compassionate Intervention Centres. Each centre will have 150 beds and provide adult patients with access to a full spectrum of mental health and addiction supports to address complex needs. Culturally based and inclusive supports will also be available. Construction is expected to begin in 2026 and be completed in 2029.

Youth will be supported in separate centres, including the Northern Alberta Youth Recovery Centre and spaces currently operating as protective safe houses for the *Protection of Children Abusing Drugs Act*.

Evidence informed

Alberta's compassionate intervention model incorporates the best elements of models from around the world. No single jurisdiction mirrors Alberta's proposed framework.

The Canadian Centre of Recovery Excellence published a policy white paper on effective compassionate intervention. It recommended several key strategies to optimize outcomes for those subject to care under compassionate intervention, which are being considered and incorporated as appropriate into the framework.

Visit recoveryexcellence.org to read the white paper.

Supporting ongoing recovery

Existing research and evidence point to the need for ongoing supports and services beyond the compassionate intervention treatment period.

The Alberta Recovery Model was developed to support Albertans struggling with mental health or addiction with an opportunity to pursue recovery and live a purpose-filled life.

Significant strides have been made to expand access to evidence-based treatment and recovery supports under the five key focus areas of the Alberta Recovery Model.

Alberta Recovery Model's five key focus areas:

Increase access to treatment

- Added more than 10,000 new publicly funded mental health and addiction treatment spaces, a 55 per cent increase in capacity within the system.
- Introduced therapeutic living units and transitional services to provincial correctional and remand centres, providing incarcerated individuals addiction treatment options.

Remove barriers to care

- Eliminated \$40 per day user fees for publicly funded mental health and addiction treatment spaces.
- Covered the cost of the opioid agonist treatment (OAT) drug Sublocade, which can help with stabilization and enhanced protection against overdose.
- Implemented immediate, no cost coverage for OAT.
- Developed the Digital Overdose Response System (DORS) to help prevent fatal drug overdose among people using substances alone.
- Partnered with police services to provide increased mental health and addiction support.

Build new facilities

- Committed \$350 million to build 11 recovery communities, three of which are open and supporting Albertans.
- Invested \$27 million to build the Northern Alberta Youth Recovery Centre.
- Building three live-in youth mental health treatment facilities in partnership with CASA Mental Health.
- Committed \$180 million for two compassionate intervention centres.

Build better futures

- Increasing school-based mental health supports for children and youth.
- Expanded the Virtual Opioid Dependency Program (VODP) to provide youth with same-day addiction medicine treatment.
- Providing children and youth with access to free virtual counselling and crisis supports.

Make treatment immediately available

- Partnered with Counselling Alberta to provide affordable counselling options across Alberta.
- Providing same-day addiction medicine treatment through VODP.
- Introduced VODP to arrest processing units to provide immediate addiction treatment options.
- Expanded 211 Alberta to connect those in need with local supports and services.